

Five Evenings at the Table

Before we stand up: reading, given circumstances, character and scene work for Six Characters in Search of an Author · Village Players, Lausanne · dir. Kiarash Jamshidi

Thursdays 2 · 9 · 16 · 23 · 30 July 2026 · 18:00–21:00 · SSA Lausanne

Table work is the round of seated readings that comes before any bodies move — the company, the director, the AD and the SM sitting together to build one shared, concrete world out of the text before staging interprets it. Its purpose is not to perform the play but to discover it: to agree the facts, to surface the questions, to name what each scene is really about, and to do enough of this that the August floor work has a spine to build on — and no more, because, as Stanislavski concluded late in his career after decades of work at the Moscow Art Theatre, too much seated analysis traps actors in their heads and divorces thinking from doing. He came to distrust long table rehearsal precisely for opening a gap between the actor's mental and physical work — "the best analysis of a play is to take action in the given circumstances." So these five July evenings are deliberately tight: we read to discover, not to perform, and we get up the moment talk stops earning its keep. The August staging block (20 Aug–1 Nov) is where bodies start to move.

A note on the calendar, because the plan must be honest about it. The edition's master schedule (lines 1782–1803) lays out SEVEN Thursday evenings, 18 June through 30 July 2026: 18 June first full read; 25 June production walk-through (the two stage objects introduced); 2 July Act One; 9 July Act Two; 16 July Act Three; 23 July Light & Sound walk-through and difficult scenes; 30 July full read with cues. This plan is a deliberate COMPRESSION of that block into the five July Thursdays only. We fold the 18 June first read and the 25 June walk-through-with-objects into Session 1 (2 July); we then take the acts in the edition's own order — Act One on 9 July, Act Two on 16 July, Act Three on 23 July — and distribute the 23 July Light & Sound walk-through across those act sessions and the final cue-called read on 30 July. We do not claim fidelity to a "five-Thursday schedule"; the edition has seven, and where we diverge we say so. The trade-off is real and is named at the top of the relevant sessions.

This is a director's edition of Pirandello's "Six Characters in Search of an Author" for the Village Players, a semi-amateur English-language company in Lausanne — and the play sets a specific trap that the table work exists to disarm. Played as farce, the Step-Daughter's near-prostitution, the child's drowning and the Boy's suicide land as gags; played as cold philosophy, the Characters' anguish goes flat and the audience watches an essay. The correct register is Pirandello's own umorismo. In *L'Umorismo* (1908) he splits the idea in two: the merely comic is the *avvertimento del contrario* — the bare perception of the opposite, where you just laugh; umorismo proper is the *sentimento del contrario* — the feeling of the opposite, which arises only when reflection intervenes and turns the laugh bitter. The directorial key is to make the laugh curdle: the company earns the *avvertimento* (you laugh at Madame Pace's accent, at the Manager's vanity) and then, a breath later, reflection drops the floor out and the same beat becomes the *sentimento* (you regret laughing). Get the register wrong and the whole production fails its subject. Concretely that means the company must learn, out loud and before staging, which layer of the play's nested fictions each performer inhabits and what that asks of them.

The plan runs across FIVE Thursday evenings — 2, 9, 16, 23 and 30 July 2026, 18:00–21:00 at SSA Lausanne — in a deliberate arc, compressed from the edition's seven. The first evening reads the whole play aloud and lays the foundations: the room and safety agreement (the company's own time-out word, check-in and de-role), the production concept, the metatheatricality and the layers of reality in the edition's own terms (Actors-playing-Actors; the Manager who plays a director first; the six fixed Characters; Madame Pace as the conjured seventh), the given circumstances and the world, and the two stage objects entering. The middle three take the acts in turn at the table in

the edition's order — Act One (the family arrives and the bargain) on 9 July, Act Two (the casting, Madame Pace's apparition, the shower monologue and the music) on 16 July, Act Three (the philosophy duel, the Son's refusal, the fountain and the two deaths) on 23 July — building from director-led world-building toward line-level action work, marking the tempo gears within each act, and on the Act Three evening talking through (never staging) the play's choreographed-contact moments. The last evening runs the whole play integrated, with cues called by the SM, to feel relationship and tempo-rhythm end to end, to confirm the safety frameworks before the floor, and to hand off cleanly to 20 August.

The methods are matched to a semi-amateur room and kept practical: Katie Mitchell's objective world-building (facts/questions, back-history, the world of the play, immediate circumstances, events, intentions) as the director-led spine; Stanislavski's units, objectives, super-objective and through-line; actioning (one transitive verb per thought) as the line-level engine, introduced only once events and intentions are agreed — a method that emerged from the Joint Stock workshop process co-led by Max Stafford-Clark and Bill Gaskill in the late 1970s, so the cast holds it as a company rehearsal-room tool, not one director's invention; Uta Hagen's six steps as the actor's private prep checklist; Declan Donnellan's "target" to keep attention outward rather than introspective; and Keith Johnstone's status work for the company/ensemble scenes. Trauma-informed and intimacy practice (the IDC Five Pillars; Ita O'Brien's time-out and choreography; aesthetic distance / depicting-not-reliving) governs how the charged material is named, agreed and deferred; the company adopts the time-out word, check-in/de-role and intake channel as its own practices in Session 1, distinct from the separately signed protocol. Everything is tied to this edition's own decisions — the four-stage Father arc, the Mother's three silences, the Step-Daughter as moral centre, the Manager's Boy-chair pivot, the Light & Sound score, the two objects, the protocol's contact inventory — and we resist over-intellectualising throughout.

The five evenings at a glance

THURSDAY 2 JULY
2026

The whole play aloud — and the room we will work in

First full read-through of the entire play in order (folding in the edition's 18 June first read and 25 June walk-through), plus the foundations: the room and safety agreement, the production concept and the layers of reality in the edition's terms, the given circumstances, and the two stage objects entering. The front-loaded talk is deliberately trimmed so the read does not get raced.

THURSDAY 9 JULY
2026

Act One at the table — the family arrives and the bargain

Act One worked seated, part by part (Rehearsal / Family Arrives / Bargain): facts and questions resolved into decisions, units and objectives, actioning, the Father's four-stage defence ladder, the Step-Daughter as moral centre, the Mother's first silence and her fragile lines — and the words-only groundwork for the Father lifting the Mother's veil, the one moment a body acts on her.

THURSDAY 16 JULY
2026

Act Two at the table — the casting, the apparition, the shower monologue, and the music

Act Two worked seated: the Step-Daughter's opening shower monologue, the procedural casting scene and the failure of representation, Madame Pace's apparition (her own performer), reality vs. illusion, the music (pianist demonstrates tempo only), the tempo gears within the act, and a words-only naming of the act's choreographed-contact moments — including the 'Cry out, mother!' beat.

THURSDAY 23 JULY
2026

Act Three at the table — the philosophy duel, the refusal, the fountain, the two deaths

Act Three worked seated: the Father's philosophy duel and his four-stage arc, the Son's refusal and mirror speech, the fountain and the two deaths, the Manager's Boy-chair pivot and the ending — the rupture-tempi around the two climaxes — and a careful talked-through (not staged) agreement of the play's choreographed-contact moments, with the gunshot and drowning handled as object work.

THURSDAY 30 JULY
2026

The whole play, integrated, with cues — and the hand-off to the floor

A full integrated read of the whole play with the SM calling cues aloud — Act Two given equal time to Acts One and Three — to feel relationships and tempo-rhythm end to end; the nervous-not-punchline comedy and 'Valentine' as a wounded provocation; the safety frameworks confirmed; and a clean hand-off to 20 August. The close-out business is kept light so the read can be a true full read.

How we run the room

GROUND RULES

- The room is the work of K. J., "offered as starting points, not as commands" (Portraits, line 1519). At the table we test the readings; we do not perform them. We read to discover, not to correct, and nobody fixes a line reading or locks a character "take" before the relationships have been explored.
- The production's own trauma-informed practices — co-written with the company in Session 1, NOT clauses of the signed protocol. The time-out word: anyone may say "hold" at any moment, for any reason, with no explanation owed and no penalty. We agree and rehearse it on 2 July, before it is ever needed, so it is a normal tool and not an alarm. A daily check-in at 18:00 (one sentence each: "what do I need to take part fully tonight?") and a de-role check-out at 20:55 (name aloud one thing that is your character's and not yours, then leave it on the table). The standing reminder we adopt for ourselves: you are not your character. (These are the IDC/O'Brien-derived practices the company chooses; they are written into the Room & Safety Agreement, not into the signed Intimacy & Consent Protocol.)
- PURE TABLE WORK. Everyone stays seated all five evenings. No blocking, no movement, no physical or intimacy work of any kind at the table. The play's choreographed-contact moments — the Step-Daughter's "My passion, sir!" hand-on-shoulder; the Father lifting the Mother's veil against her will; Madame Pace's hand under the Step-Daughter's chin; the shop-scene six-inch limit and the screen disappearance; the "Cry out, mother!" head-to-shoulder contact at the end of Act Two; the Mother separating them; the Father/Son held grip in Act Three (protocol, lines 132–148) — are named and discussed in words only and explicitly deferred to the 20 August staging block, routed through the protocol (third party present, doors not closed). The back-room transaction is NOT among them: the production never stages it — "the intensity is in the report, not the display" — so we discuss it only as

WHO DOES WHAT

- Director (Kiarash Jamshidi) — leads the analysis, frames each evening, asks the company what they found before giving a reading, keeps the umorismo register (comic and unbearable in the same beat) honest, and settles Player 3's pronoun at or before Session 1 so the stage directions can be adjusted. Reads with joy and momentum on the first pass.
- Assistant Director — "second pair of eyes" (line 1826): holds a script, takes notes, tracks the agreed events/objectives/actions in the prompt copy, flags tonal drift, energy drops, and off-message comedy, runs any sub-rehearsal when the director is occupied (e.g. a Player on the Madame Pace dialect while the director works the Mother on "It's taking place now"), and briefs absentees. A valid third party for August intimacy rehearsals when not in the scene. Does not cast, block, or give acting notes directly to actors in a director's session.
- Stage Manager — "the production's spine" (line 1845): booked the five Thursdays at SSA, distributed the Director's Copy and Actor Rehearsal Script and the calendar; during the round of readings keeps attendance, the rehearsal log, and the prompt book (in pencil, key at the front), reads stage directions aloud on the first read-through and takes a rough first running time, and calls cues aloud on 30 July. Tracks props only from August. A valid third party for August intimacy rehearsals when not in the scene. Does not direct or change the script.
- The Pianist — credited as a "fourth Player" (Light & Sound, line 1745). Attends Session 3 (16 July, Act Two) to demonstrate tempo only — Satie's Gymnopédie No. 1, the Weimar-shop vamp (Weill Bilbao Song at half tempo / a vamp on Mistinguett Mon Homme) — and returns on 30 July to mark musical cues by tempo across the integrated read; seated, no staging.
- The company (the nine performers and Madame Pace's own performer) — read aloud, keep the facts/questions and Hagen sheets, write down the agreed events and actions, and carry the part-notes

the reported event the Step-Daughter's account carries, never as deferred choreography.

- The charged scenes are protected by "Bounded bodies, unbounded moral force" (Intimacy & Consent Protocol, line 201) and "the intensity is in the report, not the display" (line 125). We aim for truthful depiction, not re-living: the actor depicts the experience and stays inside the dramatic frame; we never fuel a performance from personal trauma (IDC/aesthetic-distance practice).
- Consent lives with the actor receiving an action. The Step-Daughter and the Mother (the veil moment) hold absolute veto over their contact (protocol, line 122); a substitute is held ready for each. Consent is revocable at any moment, including in performance (protocol signature, lines 207/231). The script's or director's "permission" is never the same thing as consent.
- From Session 2 (9 July) onward the Step-Daughter and the Mother keep the Child-bundle and the Boy-chair by them throughout, even at the table, "so the company sees the conventions from this session forward" (schedule note, line 1790). The objects are heavier than performers would be; treat every gesture toward them as load-bearing — and note the protocol handles the Boy's gunshot and the Child's drowning "as object, not as person" (line 122): they are careful object-handling, not actor-intimacy work.
- Speaker tags and address are Player 1 / 2 / 3 only, never the momentary role (lines 1736–1739). Player 3's pronoun is settled at or before Session 1 (the part is written for a young man or woman; the director chooses to fit the actor cast, line 1647) so the few stage directions that carry it are adjusted before the act-by-act work uses them.
- Do not over-intellectualise. We do enough table work to share the facts and the questions, then we get up in August. Every over-talked table minute is a staging minute lost. Read first, talk second; the director asks the actors what they found before offering an interpretation.
- A private intake channel — the production's own provision, not a protocol clause — is open to every performer from tonight: any personal history with

home. Quiet roles (the Mother, the Son, the Players) are asked the same questions as the leads; a round-robin in every session guarantees each speaks; no one sits idle.

sexual coercion, child loss, or suicide can be disclosed confidentially to the director or AD without being named to the company.

- This is a deliberate FIVE-July-Thursday compression of the edition's seven-Thursday table-work block (master schedule, lines 1782–1803). We fold the edition's 18 June first read and 25 June walk-through-with-objects into Session 1 (2 July), and distribute the 23 July Light & Sound walk-through across the act sessions and the final cue-called read. We do not claim to reproduce the edition's calendar; where we depart from it we say so.

BRING TO EVERY SESSION

- Director's Copy and Actor Rehearsal Script (Storer translation, lightly modernised and trimmed for pace — "compressed, never gutted", line 1684), distributed by the SM before Session 1.
- A pencil and a two-column Facts / Questions sheet per actor (Mitchell), plus a one-page Hagen six-step sheet (Who am I? / circumstances / relationships / what do I want? / obstacle / what do I do to get it?) to fill for each scene.
- A short transitive-verb list for actioning (from Caldarone & Lloyd-Williams, *Actions: The Actors' Thesaurus*) — verbs that fit "I ____ you" (shock, reassure, intrigue, seduce, tease, threaten, distract).
- The Child-bundle (white swaddling cloth) and the Boy-chair (wooden chair, black coat, schoolboy's cap, leather satchel) — present from Session 2 on, kept by the Step-Daughter and the Mother.
- The printed, co-written Room & Safety Agreement (drafted Session 1, posted thereafter — the production's own trauma-informed practices) and a copy of the signed Intimacy & Consent Protocol for reference, including its contact inventory (lines 132–148).
- The Light & Sound one-pager (three colours in Act One and the wing radio; the shower and the pianist in Act Two; dark stage / lit fountain / hanging bulb / cello drone / Pärt in Act Three). The pianist brings the instrument for Session 3 and returns for Session 5.
- Water, tea, and something to eat for the 19:10 break and the short second break; name tags for anyone new on Session 1.

SHAPE OF AN EVENING

A single Thursday evening, 18:00–21:00 at SSA Lausanne, everyone seated throughout. 18:00 one-sentence check-in and the evening's frame (5 min). 18:05 a gentle seated vocal/breath warm-up to arrive in the voice (10 min) — the sessions are vocally heavy, so we rest the voice deliberately; this happens EVERY evening, Session 1 included (its read is the most demanding of all). 18:15 first focused reading/analysis block (~55 min). 19:10 a 15-minute break (the trauma-informed/Equity baseline we adopt: a real break inside every 80 minutes). 19:25 second block, itself broken by a scheduled 5-minute second break around 20:05–20:10 to honour the 80-minute rule across the charged back half (anyone may also call "hold" for a 2-minute pause at any time). A short round-robin so every actor — including the quiet roles — speaks aloud before the close, in EVERY session. Homework set around 20:50; de-role check-out and close at 20:55. The architecture matters more than the clock; we may run a beat long or short inside the window, but we stop talking the moment talk stops earning its keep. Session 1 carries more foundational material than a normal evening, so its read is protected by trimming the front-loaded talk (see Session 1) rather than racing the text.

REMEMBER Table work serves the floor — we read to discover, not to perform, and we get up the moment talk stops earning its keep.

The methods we use

Read to discover, not to perform (and then get up)

Read scenes through before opening discussion; the director asks the actors what they found before offering a reading. Do enough table work to share the facts and questions, then carry the analysis onto the August floor rather than exhausting it seated.

WHY Late in his career, after decades of work at the MAT, Stanislavski came to distrust long table analysis because it opened a gap between the actor's mental and physical work — "the best analysis of a play is to take action in the given circumstances." Alfreds and Donnellan restate the caution against over-fixing. For a limited-evening company every over-talked table night is a staging night lost, so tightness is a value, not a shortcut.

Hold the umorismo — comic and unbearable in the same beat

Refuse both failure modes: farce (the wounds become gags) and cold philosophy (the anguish goes flat). Keep the laugh and the wound simultaneous: "earn the laugh, then let it curdle in the same breath" (Step-Daughter, Valentine); "the comedy must cost something — every laugh uncomfortable, never a punchline" (Act One playing-note, line 1990).

WHY Pirandello's 1908 L'Umorismo splits the register in two: the merely comic is the avvertimento del contrario — the bare perception of the opposite, where you just laugh; umorismo proper is the sentimento del contrario — the reflective feeling that reverses the laugh into the painful thing underneath. The "curdle" the edition asks for IS the move from avvertimento to sentimento: Madame Pace's audience "must laugh at her first line... must regret laughing by her last" (line 2991). Naming the two terms makes the register teachable — the cast knows exactly which half they are missing when a beat plays as a mere joke. Get it wrong and the whole production fails its subject.

Know which layer of the play you are in, minute to minute

Name aloud the nested fictions and place every performer in one, in the edition's own terms: the contingent, vain Actors-playing-Actors; the Manager, who "plays a director first" and becomes the audience's stand-in only because he reacts as they do (line 1601); the six fixed Characters who are condemned to BE their one scene; and Madame Pace, conjured by the arrangement of the stage as "the seventh Character — and now her own performer" (line 1665). For the Mother, do not import "doesn't know she has a role" theory; use the edition's behavioural language — see principle 4.

WHY Pirandello invented the modern theatre-within-the-theatre with this play and the architecture is the meaning; the central conflict is ontological — who is more real. The edition's only explicit count is the seven Characters (the Six plus Madame Pace as the seventh, line 1665), and it asks the Manager to be played as a tired director first, not as "I am the audience" (line 1601). Actors who do not know their layer cannot play the collisions the play runs on.

Score the objects and the silences, not the tears

Build the Mother's role "around the object, not around tears" — the Child-bundle as her anchor (checked when men argue, covered when attacked, held lower when the Son turns away, first felt gone before the fountain) and the three distinct silences played differently. Protect her four fragile lines (But you drove me away; My son —; Stop him; Not in front of her), each given "a half-second of its own air." Her one charged contact — the Father lifting her veil against her will in Act One — is hers to control: her actor holds the speed of the lift and an absolute veto (protocol, lines 134, 122), and it is worked in words at the table and choreographed in August.

WHY The Mother is "the fixed wound of the family, and the production's silent centre" (line 1538); the edition's division is that "the Father explains the wound, the Step-Daughter exposes it, the Son refuses it — and the Mother carries it." She "does not become cleverer... she becomes more unavoidable." Her keystone "It's taking place now" is "the key to the whole production" (line 3093). The veil-lift is the one moment a body acts on her against her will, so her control of it is load-bearing and must be named at the table before any body can carry it.

Keep the focus outward — target and action, not introspection

For each beat name the specific external thing the character needs and what they are doing to whom: one transitive verb per thought (actioning: "I [verb] you" — shock, reassure, seduce, threaten), and a specific target at a measurable distance (Donnellan). Redirect any "I feel..." note into "what am I doing this to, and what does it have that I need?"

WHY Donnellan: "you can never know what you are doing until you first know what you are doing it to." Actioning — developed in the Joint Stock workshop process co-led by Stafford-Clark and Gaskill, so it is a rehearsal-room company method — gives "a clarity of purpose for every line" and a choice that is recoverable and repeatable over a run, exactly what a semi-amateur cast needs to stay consistent. It also keeps the Father from lecturing ("panic hidden under intelligence, never a lecture", line 1990) and the Step-Daughter forensic ("evidence laid down, not anger screamed").

Bounded bodies, unbounded moral force — depict, never re-live

Name the play's choreographed-contact moments plainly and establish each one's function (IDC Context pillar): the Step-Daughter's "My passion, sir!" hand-on-shoulder; the Father lifting the Mother's veil; Madame Pace's hand under the chin; the shop-scene six-inch limit and the screen disappearance; the "Cry out, mother!" head-to-shoulder contact at the end of Act Two; the Mother separating them; the Father/Son held grip in Act Three (protocol, lines 132–148). Agree they will be set as binding choreography in August, never improvised, with a third party present; the goal is truthful depiction inside the frame, not re-experiencing (aesthetic distance). The back-room transaction is NOT staged and is not on this list — it is the reported event the Step-Daughter's account carries (line 114). The Boy's gunshot and the Child's drowning are object-handling "as object, not as person" (line 122), heavy and careful, not actor-intimacy work. At the table we discuss and lay groundwork only.

WHY The protocol's governing line is "Bounded bodies, unbounded moral force" (line 201) and "the intensity is in the report, not the display" (line 125). The protocol is explicit that the back room is never shown (line 114) and that the most physically demanding actor-contact beat after the shop scene is the "Cry out, mother!" moment (line 144) — so the table talk must track the protocol's actual inventory, not an invented triad. Literature on trauma-informed training is explicit that fuelling performance with personal trauma scars performers; choreography converts a dangerous improvisation into a repeatable, safe sequence. The play is itself about the ethics of depiction.

The Sessions

The whole play aloud — and the room we will work in

First full read-through of the entire play in order (folding in the edition's 18 June first read and 25 June walk-through), plus the foundations: the room and safety agreement, the production concept and the layers of reality in the edition's terms, the given circumstances, and the two stage objects entering. The front-loaded talk is deliberately trimmed so the read does not get raced.

GOALS FOR THE EVENING

- Hear the whole play aloud, in context, for the first time as a company — for flow, tone and the umorismo register, not for correction — with enough time budgeted that the read is never raced.
- Co-write and post the Room & Safety Agreement (the company's OWN trauma-informed practices): the time-out word ("hold"), the check-in / de-role check-out, the private intake channel, and the standing reminder that you are not your character — distinct from the separately signed Intimacy & Consent Protocol.
- Establish the production concept (Storer, modern dress, minimal sculptural staging, nine performers, three stripped settings, two stage objects) and the layers of reality in the edition's terms (Actors-playing-Actors; the Manager who plays a director first; the six fixed Characters; Madame Pace the conjured seventh).
- Settle Player 3's pronoun (director's call, to fit the actor cast) so the few stage directions that carry it can be adjusted before the act work, and begin the shared given circumstances using Mitchell's facts/questions.
- Introduce the Boy-chair and the Child-bundle as conventions and the rule that they sit by the Step-Daughter and the Mother from next week; name the protocol's contact inventory at a high level and that the back room is reported, never staged.

THE EVENING, HOUR BY HOUR

18:00

Welcome, check-in, and the frame

Name tags for anyone new; the director signals "one team, one goal" and keeps it short. One-sentence check-in from each person. The director frames the evening and names the compression: tonight folds the edition's first read and walk-through into one, so we keep the talk tight and protect the read.

18:05

Seated vocal/breath warm-up

10-minute gentle seated warm-up before any reading — Session 1 carries the most vocally demanding work of the block (a full read-aloud), so we warm up cold voices first, not after 20 minutes of policy talk.

18:15

Co-write the Room & Safety Agreement (the production's own practices)

Brief and collaborative: agree and rehearse the time-out word "hold"; agree the check-in and de-role check-out; name the private intake channel; settle Player 3's pronoun. Read aloud the protocol's governing line "Bounded bodies, unbounded moral force" and that the five Thursdays are table work only. State plainly that these practices are the company's own (IDC/O'Brien-derived), written into the Room & Safety Agreement, NOT clauses of the signed protocol. SM posts the agreement. Keep to 15 minutes.

18:30

Concept and the layers of reality (compressed)

Director lays out modern dress, minimal sculptural staging, the three stripped settings, and the layers in the edition's terms: Actors-playing-Actors, the Manager who plays a director first (line 1601), the six fixed Characters, Madame Pace the conjured seventh (line 1665). 15 minutes, concrete not lecturing. Deeper given-circumstances and the bulk of facts/questions move to the response block and to Session 2.

18:45

First read-through — Act One

Full company reads Act One aloud in order, seated (~40 min). SM reads stage directions and starts a rough

running time. Director reads with momentum, pausing only to clarify a tricky word or a Lausanne reference. No stopping to fix readings.

19:25

Break (15 min)

Water, tea, food. Rest the voice — the read is vocally heavy.

19:40

First read-through — Acts Two and Three

Read straight through Acts Two and Three to the fountain, the two deaths and the Manager's exit (~70 min, with a 2-minute breather mid-way if the voice tires). SM closes the running time. Let the ending sit in silence before anyone speaks.

20:50

Actors first, objects in, and round-robin close

Compressed close (the deeper facts/questions move to homework and Session 2): a fast round-robin so EVERY performer — including the Mother, the Son and the Players — says one instinct aloud about the play or their character before the director offers any reading; the director introduces the Child-bundle and Boy-chair as conventions and assigns them to the Step-Daughter and Mother from next week, naming that the protocol's contact moments (veil, chin, shop-scene limit, Cry out mother, the grip) are choreographed in August and the back room is reported, never staged. Set homework; de-role check-out; confirm next Thursday.

EXERCISES AT THE TABLE

The protected first read

Read the whole play aloud in order with minimal interruption (clarify words only), Act One before the break and Acts Two–Three after, time-budgeted so no act is raced. SM reads stage directions and times it; the front-loaded concept/policy talk is trimmed to make room.

YIELDS Gets the play heard in context, with joy and momentum, without the read being crushed into a fraction of the evening (Theatrefolk / The Scene; read first, talk second).

Facts & Questions, round one (seeded, finished as homework)

Each actor keeps two columns while listening; the company pools a handful of facts and questions in the brief close, then completes the sheet at home. Questions are parked to be answered (decided) over the coming weeks, not left as ambiguity.

YIELDS Mitchell's foundational exercise — builds an objective, evidence-based shared world and "inhibits premature attempts to interpret the play." Seeded tonight, finished as homework so the read keeps its time.

Naming your layer (round-robin)

Going round the table, each performer says aloud which layer they live in, in the edition's terms: Actor-playing-Actor / the Manager-as-tired-director / a fixed Character / Madame Pace the conjured seventh.

YIELDS Makes the metatheatrical concrete and personal from night one and guarantees every quiet role speaks; the layer you inhabit governs every collision in the play.

QUESTIONS TO PUT TO THE ROOM

- *Where did the room laugh tonight — and did the laugh have a wound under it (the sentimento), or was it just funny (the avvertimento)? What would it take to make it cost something?*
- *Who felt 'more real' as we read — the Characters or the Actors? Where did that flip?*
- *For your character: which layer of the play do you live in, and how did that change how you listened tonight?*
- *What is one fact about the world of this play we can all agree on, and one question we genuinely cannot answer yet?*

HOMEWORK

Read the whole play again alone, pencil in hand, and complete your personal Facts / Questions sheet for your own scenes (Mitchell). Begin a Hagen six-step sheet for your character's first scene. Note one place where the comedy and the wound sit in the same beat. Read your part-note (the Portraits gallery) once, as a starting point to test — not a command. Begin learning Act One lines now: the interim milestone is Act One off-book by Thursday 20 August (the floor's first day), with the rest progressively across the staging block — words don't seep in by osmosis.

BY THE END

By the end you have heard the whole play aloud once (a genuine read, not a raced one), a rough running time logged by the SM, a co-written and posted Room & Safety Agreement of the company's own practices (time-out word, check-in/de-role, intake channel), Player 3's pronoun settled, a first map of the world in facts and questions seeded, every performer placed in a layer of the play, and the two stage objects introduced and assigned from next week — with the protocol's contact inventory named and the back room understood as reported, never staged.

Act One at the table — the family arrives and the bargain

Act One worked seated, part by part (Rehearsal / Family Arrives / Bargain): facts and questions resolved into decisions, units and objectives, actioning, the Father's four-stage defence ladder, the Step-Daughter as moral centre, the Mother's first silence and her fragile lines — and the words-only groundwork for the Father lifting the Mother's veil, the one moment a body acts on her.

GOALS FOR THE EVENING

- Turn the Act One questions into agreed decisions and a shared immediate-circumstances picture (the 24 hours before each part).
- Divide Act One into units and name a playable objective for each; begin actioning the key exchanges with transitive verbs; mark the tempo gear-change between Part I 'dry and worn' and the Father/Step-Daughter drive so tempo is built here, not discovered on 30 July.
- Score the Father's Act One defence as an escalation, not a repetition: I meant well → you misunderstand me → do not judge me by one moment → I am trapped by what she says I am.
- Establish the Step-Daughter's through-line (stop making this beautiful / clever / safe — this happened, look at it) and play the Madame Pace material forensically, evidence not screamed; the back-room transaction is discussed in words only as the REPORTED event her account carries, never as deferred choreography.
- Place and protect the Mother's first silence and her four fragile lines; do words-only groundwork on the Father lifting her veil (its dramatic function, that her actor controls the speed and holds veto, flagged for August choreography); confirm the Child-bundle / Boy-chair convention now sits with her and the Step-Daughter.

THE EVENING, HOUR BY HOUR

18:00	Check-in and warm-up One-sentence check-in; seated vocal/breath warm-up. The Step-Daughter and the Mother take up the Child-bundle and the Boy-chair and keep them by them for the rest of the evening (line 1790).
18:15	Part I — dry and worn, and its tempo gear Read Act One Part I (the company's tired rehearsal). Apply the playing-note: "play Part I dry and worn — the company is tired, not performing wit; keep the comedy deadpan, add nothing beyond what is written" (line 1891). Resolve the parked Part I questions into decisions; agree the immediate circumstances (the wasted morning). Mark the tempo gear here — the loose, worn company pulse — against the airless drive the Six bring.
18:40	Units & objectives — the Family Arrives Divide the arrival of the Six into units marked by turning points; name one playable objective per unit as an active verb. Note where the Manager is "playing a director first," not 'I am the audience' (line 1601). Mark the tempo gear-change as the Father/Step-Daughter drive enters.
19:10	Break (15 min) Rest the voice; water and food.
19:25	The Father's escalation ladder + actioning Work the Father's long speeches as "panic hidden under intelligence, never a lecture" (line 1990). Lay the

four rungs in order and action a sample of his lines with one transitive verb per thought (justify, disarm, plead, trap). Mark the autobiographical-as-metaphysical reading: every speech argues him back into being someone the room can listen to.

19:55

The Step-Daughter forensic — the bargain

Action her attack as "evidence laid down, not anger screamed; cold revenge, not melodrama." From Madame Pace onward, agree the comedy "must cost something — every laugh uncomfortable, never a punchline." Find one or two moments where the cleverness drops and the hurt shows ("sharpest when wounded, not clever"). The back-room transaction is discussed in words only AS THE REPORTED EVENT her account carries (protocol line 114) — it is never staged, so it is not deferred choreography.

20:05

Second break (5 min)

Short scheduled breather to honour the 80-minute rule across the charged back half. Rest the voice.

20:10

The Mother — first silence, fragile lines, and the veil (words only)

Place her first silence ("a woman who does not yet believe the room will hear her"). Read each fragile line — But you drove me away; My son —; Stop him; Not in front of her — giving each "a half-second of its own air." Score her hands on the Child-bundle (grip tightens by one knuckle when accused). Then the veil-lift in words only: name its dramatic function (a man acts on her against her will), confirm her actor controls the speed of the lift and holds absolute veto (protocol lines 134, 122), and flag it for choreographed-and-consented August staging — parallel to how the back-room is handled for the Step-Daughter tonight. No physical work.

20:40

Round-robin: what does your character want in Act One?

Every actor, including the Players, names their Act One objective and target out loud. The Players settle their Lausanne register — local, modern, amateur-in-the-best-sense.

20:50

Homework and de-role close

Set homework; de-role check-out; confirm next Thursday.

EXERCISES AT THE TABLE

Units & objectives mapping

Read each part; mark a slash at every turning point to divide it into units; write one active-verb objective per unit, threading them toward each character's super-objective. Actors write them down (Mitchell's sequence: agree events/intentions, then read using them as a guide).

YIELDS Stanislavski/Mitchell: gives the act a beat-by-beat structure of change and a through-line, so nothing is played as undifferentiated 'emotion'.

Actioning the Father and the Step-Daughter

Each takes their own lines, splits them into thoughts, and assigns one transitive verb per thought that fits "I ____ you" (Caldarone & Lloyd-Williams thesaurus). Speak the line in the manner of the verb, aimed at the specific person — seated, no movement.

YIELDS Joint Stock / Stafford-Clark & Gaskill actioning: "a clarity of purpose for every line" and a repeatable choice — keeps the Father from lecturing and the Step-Daughter forensic rather than melodramatic.

The fragile-line air check, with the veil named

The Mother reads each of her four lines while the louder actors deliberately do NOT roll over her; the room gives each line a half-second of silence on either side and notes the cost in her hands on the bundle. Then the veil-lift is described in words only — function, her speed control, her veto — and flagged for August.

YIELDS Protects the production's silent centre at the table, in timing, and gives her one charged contact its words-only groundwork before any staging can bury her (line 1547; protocol line 134).

QUESTIONS TO PUT TO THE ROOM

- *Where exactly does the Father's defence move up a rung — and where is he merely repeating himself (which the edition forbids)?*
- *The Step-Daughter is 'the moral centre, not the Father with his philosophy.' Where in Act One does the room first feel that?*
- *What is each Player actually doing while the Six argue — what is their objective in the room?*
- *Where should a laugh in the bargain land, and how do we make sure it 'costs something' — turns from avvertimento to sentimento?*
- *The veil-lift is the one moment a body acts on the Mother. What is its dramatic function, and what does her holding the speed and the veto protect?*

HOMEWORK

Finalise your units-and-objectives for Act One and your Hagen sheet for your Act One scene, grounded in tonight's agreed facts. Father: write your four rungs in your own words and one transitive verb per major speech. Step-Daughter: action the Madame Pace evidence as cold testimony. Mother: rehearse your four fragile lines aloud at home with a half-second of air around each, decide what your hands do on the Child-bundle at three named moments, and sit with the veil-lift's function (its choreography waits for August). Players: bring your Lausanne register choice. Keep learning Act One lines toward the 20 August off-book milestone.

BY THE END

By the end you have Act One divided into units with an agreed playable objective for each, the Part I / Father-drive tempo gear marked, a sample of the Father's and Step-Daughter's key lines actioned, the Father's four-rung escalation laid in order, the Step-Daughter's forensic through-line agreed (the back room understood as reported, not staged), the Mother's first silence placed, her four fragile lines protected in timing, the veil-lift's function and her control of it established in words, and the Child-bundle / Boy-chair convention now at the table.

Act Two at the table — the casting, the apparition, the shower monologue, and the music

Act Two worked seated: the Step-Daughter's opening shower monologue, the procedural casting scene and the failure of representation, Madame Pace's apparition (her own performer), reality vs. illusion, the music (pianist demonstrates tempo only), the tempo gears within the act, and a words-only naming of the act's choreographed-contact moments — including the 'Cry out, mother!' beat.

GOALS FOR THE EVENING

- Honour the act's true shape: the Step-Daughter's monologue OPENS Act Two (she erupts onto the upper platform with both objects before the procedural casting scene, lines 2591, 2621); we read it early so the company feels the brisk-procedural-vs-exposed-solo contrast in its real order.
- Work the procedural stretches "brisk and businesslike" so the shower-light, the apparition and the Mother's cry land hard against them (line 2595); mark the tempo gears within the act so Session 5 confirms tempo rather than discovering it.
- Understand the casting scene as the failure of representation — the Leading Man and Leading Lady falsify the scene on purpose; use Johnstone status work to map the company's power dynamics.
- Build Madame Pace as apparition and bookkeeper — full comic accent on arrival, full obscenity by exit, "the bookkeeping is the body of her," the laugh curdling on "he pay cash" (avvertimento to sentimento in one line).
- Place the Mother's second silence and her keystone line; name in words only the act's choreographed-contact moments — Madame Pace's hand under the chin, the shop-scene six-inch limit and screen disappearance, and especially the 'Cry out, mother!' head-to-shoulder contact (protocol line 144, the most demanding actor-contact beat after the shop scene) — all deferred to August.

THE EVENING, HOUR BY HOUR

18:00

Check-in, warm-up, objects in place

Check-in; seated warm-up; Step-Daughter and Mother take up the Child-bundle and Boy-chair. The pianist is welcomed as the credited fourth Player and will demonstrate tempo only tonight, seated.

18:15

The opening monologue, in its true position

Read the Step-Daughter's single sustained monologue at the top of the act, where it actually sits (lines 2591, 2621): she erupts onto the upper platform with both objects — tender to the Child-bundle, then the wound turned the other way at the Boy-chair. Read seated; the revolver-from-the-pocket is discussed as a future staged/choreographed moment, deferred to August. Find the depicting-not-reliving line out loud. We read it first so the company feels the act open as the script opens it.

18:40

The casting scene — brisk, and the failure of representation

Read the casting/procedural stretch businesslike and quick, landing hard against the exposed solo just heard. Establish that the Leading Man and Leading Lady are BAD at re-enacting the Characters on purpose — "the horror is that it is good, and still false" (line 3093). Player 2's wound: "I have been made a fool of by considerably better" is "not a punchline. It is the truth" (line 3133). Mark the act's tempo gears — procedural brisk vs. exposed solo vs. the airless apparition.

19:10	Break (15 min) Rest the voice; water and food.
19:25	Status work on the company Johnstone play-the-status read: run a slice of the casting scene with the company actors deliberately a point higher, then a point lower, then alternating raise/lower line by line — seated, voice and eye-contact only. Maps who does what to whom in power terms (the Manager, the vain Player 1, the working Player 2, the curious Player 3 with the notebook).
19:50	Madame Pace — apparition and bookkeeping Read the aria. "Play the comedy of her accent at full strength on her arrival; play the obscenity beneath it at full strength by her exit" (line 1667). "Do not let her become an accent joke. The bookkeeping is the body of her." Mark the curdle precisely on "he clean, he polite, he pay cash" — the bare comic perception (avvertimento) turning to the reflective disgust (sentimento). The Step-Daughter "does not flirt with Madame Pace; she is being handled by her"; Madame Pace's hand-under-the-chin is named as a choreographed-contact moment for August. Words only.
20:05	Second break (5 min) Short scheduled breather across the charged back half. Rest the voice.
20:10	The pianist demonstrates tempo Pianist plays, seated, tempo only: Satie's Gymnopédie No. 1 (the speed it will sit under the monologue, once through); the Weimar-shop vamp (Weill Bilbao Song at half tempo / a vamp on Mistinguett Mon Homme) and exactly where it dies mid-bar on "You old devil. You murderess." No staging — the company hears the tempo gears.
20:25	The Mother's keystone, and naming the act's contact moments Place the Mother's second silence (being made to watch her daughter's worst hour) and the breath on which it breaks at "he pay cash." Read "It's taking place now. It happens all the time" — "like a stone learning to speak" — naming it the key to the whole production. Then, words only, name the act's choreographed-contact moments to be set in August: Madame Pace's hand under the chin; the shop-scene six-inch limit and the two-second screen disappearance; and the 'Cry out, mother!' contact at the end of the act — the Step-Daughter's cheek to the Father's shoulder, one hand on his upper arm, he does not reciprocate, the Mother breaks them (protocol line 144) — flagged as the most demanding actor-contact beat after the shop scene.
20:45	Round-robin and close Fast round-robin so every actor — the Mother, the Son, each Player — names one thing they found in Act Two; set homework; de-role check-out; confirm next Thursday.

EXERCISES AT THE TABLE

Play-the-status casting read

Run the casting scene seated, first with each company actor one status point higher than instinct, then one lower, then alternating raise-self / lower-partner line by line (Johnstone), using only voice, eye-contact and the 'er' marker — no movement.

YIELDS Johnstone: makes the company's ensemble power dynamics legible and tunable, which is exactly what the vain/working/curious trio and the Manager need; clarifies who blocks and who accepts.

The curdle-point mark-up

Read Madame Pace's aria and, as a room, agree and pencil the precise word where the avvertimento (the laugh) must turn to the sentimento (disgust) — 'he pay cash' — and where the vamp dies mid-bar ('You old devil. You murderess.'). Pianist demonstrates the tempo of both.

YIELDS Locks the umorismo mechanics of the play's most sensitive sequence in sound and timing before staging — "the audience must laugh at her first line... regret laughing by her last."

Seated read of the opening monologue with the objects

Step-Daughter reads the monologue once through at the top of the session, seated, holding the Child-bundle and addressing the Boy-chair, Satie tempo underneath later; the room listens in silence. Discussion of the revolver beat stays verbal and is deferred to August.

YIELDS Lets the production's most exposed solo be heard in its true opening position (lines 2591, 2621), so the company feels the act's actual shape, while honouring the table-work-only and depict-not-relive rules.

QUESTIONS TO PUT TO THE ROOM

- *When the Leading Man and Lady re-enact the scene 'well, and still false' — what exactly is false about it, and what does that tell us about depicting vs. living?*
- *Where is Madame Pace funny (avvertimento), and where do we as a room first regret laughing (sentimento)?*
- *In the opening monologue, what does the Step-Daughter need from each silent sibling — what is her target in the Child-bundle, and in the Boy-chair?*
- *How does the Mother's 'It's taking place now' change the temperature of the whole room — and what must be silent around it?*
- *The 'Cry out, mother!' contact is the most demanding actor-contact moment after the shop scene. What does the agreed blocking protect, and what carries the closeness the bodies do not enact?*

HOMEWORK Step-Daughter: live with the opening monologue; bring a Hagen sheet for it and decide the exact turn from tenderness to the wound. Madame Pace's performer: drill the dialect with no protective irony and bookkeep the aria — know the ledger cold. Mother: rehearse the keystone line and your second silence; decide what your hands do on the Child-bundle through the aria (the grip becoming a fist on 'he pay cash'). Company actors: bring one status choice per scene. Everyone: keep learning lines toward the 20 August Act One off-book milestone and progressive off-book beyond.

BY THE END By the end you have Act Two read in its true shape (monologue opening it), its procedural spine agreed as brisk-and-businesslike, its tempo gears marked, the company's status dynamics mapped, Madame Pace built as apparition-and-bookkeeper with the curdle point marked, the Satie and Weimar-vamp tempi demonstrated and their cut-points fixed in the ear, the Mother's second silence and keystone line placed, and the act's choreographed-contact moments named in words — Madame Pace's chin, the shop-scene limit and screen, and the 'Cry out, mother!' beat — all deferred to August.

Act Three at the table — the philosophy duel, the refusal, the fountain, the two deaths

Act Three worked seated: the Father's philosophy duel and his four-stage arc, the Son's refusal and mirror speech, the fountain and the two deaths, the Manager's Boy-chair pivot and the ending — the rupture-tempi around the two climaxes — and a careful talked-through (not staged) agreement of the play's choreographed-contact moments, with the gunshot and drowning handled as object work.

GOALS FOR THE EVENING

- Score the Father's four-stage arc end to end: control → injury → attack → horror, escalating in desperation, "the point made in his panic, not his paragraphs" (line 3566).
- Place and time the Step-Daughter's three cuts and find where they push the Father into the wall of his own argument; mark the rupture-tempi around the two climaxes so Session 5 confirms tempo rather than discovering it.
- Work the Son's refusal ("every line is a door closing"), his single moment of looking up ("Exactly what it was, sir; exactly that"), the mirror speech (the cry found on 'horrible', not before) and the fountain narration.
- Establish the climax register — "carry it by stillness, not volume"; the Son's account flat; the Mother's discovery physical, veil never lifting; "the silence after the shot is the loudest thing in the play."
- Talk through in words only the protocol's choreographed-contact moments that fall in Act Three (the Father/Son held grip, line 148) and recap those from earlier acts; agree the gunshot and drowning are object-handling "as object, not as person" (line 122), heavy and careful, not intimacy work; and the Manager's Boy-chair pivot — all physical choreography deferred to 20 August via the protocol.

THE EVENING, HOUR BY HOUR

18:00	Check-in, warm-up, objects in place Check-in; seated warm-up; in Act Three the Mother holds both children — the Child-bundle in her lap and the Boy-chair at her knee — so both objects are by her tonight.
18:15	The philosophy duel Read Act Three Part I. Score the Father's arc: control → injury → attack → horror. Apply the playing-note: his defence "must escalate in desperation, never merely repeat... the point is made in his panic, not his paragraphs" (line 3566). Action his lines so the philosophy stays autobiographical, not abstract.
18:45	The Step-Daughter's three cuts, and the rupture-tempi Place and time her three cuts, including 'His reality. He always knew exactly where to find me.' Find how "the same Step-Daughter who exposed him in Act One pushes him into the wall in Act Three." Note the cello drone dies as she cuts him (Light & Sound). Mark the rupture-tempi: where the argument's pulse breaks open around each climax, so tempo is built here, not first met on 30 July.
19:10	Break (15 min) Rest the voice; water and food.
19:25	The Son's refusal and the two wounds Work the Son: "unmoveable, not still," every line a door closing. Read his single look-up — 'Exactly what it was, sir; exactly that' — "the only place where the Son is on the side of someone else's instinct" (line 3607).

Read the mirror speech so the cry is found mid-thought on 'horrible,' not pre-loaded; then he is more closed than before. Read the fountain narration — his only continuous sentence.

19:55

The fountain, the two deaths, the Manager's pivot

Read the climax for register: "carry it by stillness, not volume." The Son's account flat; the Child's drowning told, hidden by the basin; the Boy's gunshot heard not seen; the Mother's discovery physical with the veil never lifting; "the silence after the shot is the loudest thing in the play. Let nobody push." Name the Manager's pivot: he "sets the Boy-chair behind the fountain himself — the moment he stops being audience and becomes accessory." The closing exit is the audience's own; the last line "is not a punchline."

20:05

Second break (5 min)

Short scheduled breather across the charged Act Three material. Rest the voice — this is the most emotionally charged sit of the block.

20:10

Talked-through agreement of the contact moments

Sit with the protocol's actual contact inventory (Context pillar), words only: name each Act Three choreographed contact — the Father/Son held grip, mutual, hands on shoulders, no shaking, no face proximity (line 148) — and recap the earlier moments (the veil, the chin, the shop-scene limit and screen, the 'Cry out, mother!' beat). Confirm each will be set as binding choreography in August, third party present, routed through the protocol — never improvised. Agree the gunshot and the Child's drowning are object-handling "as object, not as person" (line 122) — heavy and careful staging, not actor-intimacy. Confirm consent lives with the receiving actor and is revocable (lines 207/231); the back room is reported, never staged (line 114). Reaffirm 'Bounded bodies, unbounded moral force.' No staging, no physical work.

20:40

Round-robin and close

Each actor — including the Mother, the Son and the Players — names their Act Three super-objective in one line; de-role check-out; set homework; confirm next Thursday is the full integrated read.

EXERCISES AT THE TABLE

Scoring the four-stage arc

The Father reads Part I while the room marks the exact lines where he moves control → injury → attack → horror; action each section with a verb that escalates in desperation. The Step-Daughter's three cuts are placed against those rungs and timed, with the rupture-tempi marked around the climaxes.

YIELDS Turns the edition's signature Father arc and the Step-Daughter's cuts into a shared, timed structure of collision — "the point is made in his panic, not his paragraphs" — and builds tempo at the table, not on the last night.

The mirror-speech surprise read

The Son reads the mirror speech twice: once trying to 'arrive' at the feeling early (to feel why that fails), then finding the cry only on the word 'horrible.' The room watches for the door-closing flatness on either side.

YIELDS Embodies the note that the cry must surprise him mid-thought and be re-buried after (lines 3608–3609); guards against result-direction and pre-loaded emotion.

Context-and-consent talk-through (the protocol's actual list)

Seated circle: name each of the protocol's choreographed-contact moments plainly (veil, chin, shop-scene limit and screen, 'Cry out mother', the Father/Son grip), state each one's dramatic function, and agree on paper how they will be choreographed and consented in August. Treat the gunshot/drowning as object-handling, and the back room as reported only. No reading-into-action, no touch — discussion only.

YIELDS IDC Context/Consent pillars and the protocol (lines 132–148): lays the groundwork so August choreography is safe and unsurprising, tracking the protocol's real inventory rather than an invented triad, while honouring the table-work-only rule.

QUESTIONS TO PUT TO THE ROOM

- *Where does the Father stop arguing and start panicking — and where does he 'walk into the wall' of his own philosophy?*
- *The Son 'agrees with the author who abandoned them.' Why does that make him the most modern, and most dangerous, figure?*
- *How do we keep the two deaths from being either gags or melodrama — what does 'carry it by stillness' ask of each of us, and how do we handle the Boy-chair and Child-bundle as objects, not bodies?*
- *For the choreographed-contact moments: what is the report or the staging that carries the weight, so the bodies don't have to? What must we agree now so August feels safe?*

HOMEWORK Father: bring your four-stage arc fully actioned, escalating not repeating. Step-Daughter: fix the timing of your three cuts. Son: live with the mirror speech so the cry lands on 'horrible'; learn the fountain narration as one continuous sentence. Mother: decide the physical shape of your discovery with the veil never lifting and both children held. Manager: sit with the Boy-chair pivot — what makes you place that chair yourself. Everyone: note any personal response to the charged material and raise it privately if you wish (intake channel open). Keep driving toward the 20 August Act One off-book milestone.

BY THE END By the end you have the Father's four-stage arc scored and actioned, the Step-Daughter's three cuts placed and timed with the rupture-tempi marked, the Son's refusal and his two wounds worked, the climax register agreed (stillness not volume; the silence after the shot protected), the Manager's Boy-chair pivot named, and a written, words-only agreement of the protocol's actual contact moments and their deferral to choreographed, consented August staging — with the gunshot and drowning understood as object work and the back room as reported, never staged.

The whole play, integrated, with cues — and the hand-off to the floor

A full integrated read of the whole play with the SM calling cues aloud — Act Two given equal time to Acts One and Three — to feel relationships and tempo-rhythm end to end; the nervous-not-punchline comedy and 'Valentine' as a wounded provocation; the safety frameworks confirmed; and a clean hand-off to 20 August. The close-out business is kept light so the read can be a true full read.

GOALS FOR THE EVENING

- Run the whole play end to end as one integrated read with the SM calling cues aloud, giving Act Two as much time as Acts One and Three (~40 min each), so the company feels the tempo gears and collisions across all three acts — confirming tempo built in Sessions 2–4, not discovering it.
- Confirm the nervous-not-punchline comedy register company-wide — Player 1's 'These are not the lines of a play I auditioned for' (line 2332), which falls in ACT ONE just before the Father's 'pity' speech (line 2334), as the model for the register — and 'Valentine' as a wounded provocation, not a number.
- Hear relationships and through-lines land across the whole arc — the Father explains / the Step-Daughter exposes / the Son refuses / the Mother carries.
- Confirm the safety frameworks before the floor: the company's time-out word, check-in/de-role, consent and veto (lines 207/231; the absolute veto line 122), and that every choreographed-contact moment in the protocol's inventory is choreographed-and-consented in August — keeping the read-back brief so it does not eat the read.
- Hand off cleanly to the 20 August staging block: confirm the staging calendar (20 Aug–1 Nov; summer break 5 & 13 Aug) and the off-book milestone (Act One off-book by 20 August, progressive thereafter).

THE EVENING, HOUR BY HOUR

18:00

Check-in, warm-up, frameworks read-back, objects in place

Check-in; seated warm-up. Step-Daughter and Mother take up the objects; pianist on hand to mark musical cues by tempo. Move the close-out business UP front so the read is unbroken later: a brief frameworks read-back (each person restates one provision of the company's Room & Safety Agreement and the deferral of the protocol's contact moments to August) and a one-line hand-off note on the August calendar. Kept to ~15 min.

18:15

Integrated read — Act One, with cues

Full company reads Act One straight through (~40 min), seated, SM calling Light & Sound cues aloud (white → amber → red; the wing radio; the absence of sound into Act Two). Hold the tempo gears: company looseness against the Father/Step-Daughter drive. 'Valentine' read as 'a provocation from a wound' — earn the laugh, then let it curdle. Confirm the nervous-not-punchline register on Player 1's '[quiet now, almost ashamed; not a punchline]' (line 2332), the Act One model line just before the Father's 'pity' speech.

18:55

Integrated read — Act Two, with cues (full time)

Read Act Two straight through with EQUAL time to the other acts (~40 min), SM calling cues (the shower; Satie; the Weimar vamp and its mid-bar death; the held chord); pianist marks the music by tempo. Keep the procedural brisk so the opening monologue, the apparition and the Mother's cry land against it. Feel the act's full tempo gears — the cue-dense centre of the play gets the time it needs, not 15 minutes.

19:35

Break (15 min)

Rest the voice; water and food.

19:50

Integrated read — Act Three, with cues

Read Act Three straight through (~40 min), SM calling cues (cello drone; the single sharp piano note; water sound; the gunshot in real silence; Spiegel im Spiegel as the lights go). Protect the silence after the shot — 'let nobody push.' Let the Manager's exit and the last line land without irony. A 2-minute breather mid-act if the voice tires.

20:30

Tempo-rhythm and relationships notes

Director gives brief, actionable, motivation-based notes on the whole arc: where tempo flattened, where a collision needs sharpening, where a relationship through-line read clearly or got rolled over — confirming the tempo gears marked in Sessions 2–4. No result-direction.

20:50

De-role close, hand-off, and thank-you

Final de-role check-out for the round of readings; the SM confirms the staging calendar (20 Aug–1 Nov; summer break 5 & 13 Aug) and the off-book milestone (Act One off-book by 20 August, progressive thereafter); the director sets the 20 August arrival expectation and thanks the company, closing the table-work block. (Detailed logistics already covered in the front-loaded read-back, so this stays short.)

EXERCISES AT THE TABLE

Cue-called integrated read, acts equally weighted

Read the whole play seated in one sitting (with the break) while the SM calls every Light & Sound cue aloud from the prompt book and the pianist marks musical cues by tempo, giving Act Two the same ~40 minutes as Acts One and Three. No stopping for line fixes; notes are saved for after the read.

YIELDS Lets the company feel tempo-rhythm, the collisions and the scored cues as one continuous experience — the closest a table read gets to the shape of the show — without starving the cue-dense Act Two, which is the centre of the play.

The 'Valentine' curdle in context

Run the Valentine turn inside the full Act One read (sung or marked), with the room having just heard she is 'two months orphaned and lately for sale'; the company notes the exact moment the laugh should curdle from avvertimento to sentimento.

YIELDS Confirms Valentine as 'a wounded provocation' not a comic number (line 1556) — "if it plays as a merely funny number, the danger underneath it has been lost."

Frameworks read-back (front-loaded)

At the top of the evening, going round the table, each person reads or restates one provision of the company's Room & Safety Agreement and the deferral of all choreographed-contact work to consented August sessions. Kept brief so the integrated read runs unbroken later.

YIELDS Confirms shared, spoken ownership of the safety frameworks before the floor (IDC/O'Brien: agreed and rehearsed before they are ever needed), without stealing time from the read.

QUESTIONS TO PUT TO THE ROOM

- *Across the whole play, where did the tempo flatten into one mid-tempo — and where did the collisions land as real ruptures, as we marked them in the act sessions?*
- *Did the comedy stay 'nervous, not a punchline' all the way through — turning from avvertimento to sentimento? Where did it tip toward farce?*
- *Did the Mother's silences and fragile lines survive the louder energy when we ran it whole?*

- *What does each of us most need from the August floor to do this safely and well — and is our safety agreement strong enough to carry it?*

HOMEWORK Have Act One off-book by 20 August (the floor's first day); memorise the rest progressively across the staging block and sit with your part-notes over the summer break; arrive on 20 August ready to be on your feet. Re-read your scenes against tonight's tempo and relationship notes. Bring any remaining questions for the charged scenes to the dedicated, choreographed August sessions — not to the floor unprepared. Note the summer-break dates (5 & 13 August) and the staging calendar (20 Aug–1 Nov).

BY THE END By the end you have read the whole play through once as an integrated, cue-called run with Act Two given its full weight; felt the tempo-rhythm, collisions and scored cues end to end (confirming what the act sessions built); confirmed the nervous-not-punchline comedy and 'Valentine' as a wounded provocation; re-confirmed the safety frameworks (time-out, check-in/de-role, consent/veto, the protocol's contact moments choreographed-and-consented in August); and handed off to the 20 August staging block with the calendar set, the Act One off-book milestone clear, and the round of readings complete.

Traps to avoid

- Directing from page one. The strongest repeated warning in the practitioner literature: do not stop-start to fix line readings or deliver interpretation before the actors have offered their own instinct. Read first, talk second. On 2 July especially, read with joy and momentum and resist correcting.
- Letting the comedy win — stopping at the avvertimento. A cast leans into the genuinely funny interruptions, the Manager's vanity, Madame Pace's accent — and the laugh never curdles, so the Step-Daughter's near-prostitution, the drowning and the suicide stay gags (the avvertimento with no sentimento). Equally fatal is playing it as cold relativism with no laugh at all. Police the umorismo every session: earn the laugh, then let reflection reverse it — "the comedy around it belongs to the company, never to the scene itself" (line 2940); "do not let her become an accent joke" (line 1667).
- Over-intellectualising / table work that never ends. Five evenings is deliberately tight — and tighter still because we have compressed the edition's seven into five. Every over-talked minute is an August staging minute lost. When talk stops earning its keep, stop talking; the discoveries that matter are made on the floor.
- Locking choices too early — director or actor. Setting a character "take" or a line reading in stone at the table "stifles golden new choices." The edition's readings are "starting points, not commands" (line 1519); the table tests them.
- Swallowing the quiet roles. A round-robin in EVERY session and Hagen homework are built so every actor speaks: the Mother, the Son and the Players (including the curious Player 3 with the notebook) are asked the same questions as the Father and the Step-Daughter. The Mother's four fragile lines must never be rolled over by louder energy.
- Drifting toward staging or physical work at the table. Per the signed protocol the five Thursdays are "table work only... No blocking. No physical work." The choreographed-contact moments (protocol lines 132–148) are discussed in words and explicitly deferred to 20 August; the back-room transaction is discussed only as the reported event, not as deferred choreography. The objects are present from 9 July but are handled as conventions, not blocked.
- Result direction ("be sad", "be louder", "get angry"). Reach the beat indirectly through action, target and circumstance. The edition models this: find the Son's cry "on the word horrible, not before" (line 3608); the Mother's outburst must "come out faster than her body can carry it" (line 2901) — never a played emotion.

- Flattening the tempo into a single mid-tempo. The play runs on interruption and collision, not flow — the loose comic naturalism of the company against the airless drive of the Father and Step-Daughter. Map the tempo gears **INSIDE** each act-session (not only on the final read) so Session 5 confirms tempo rather than discovering a problem with no table time left to fix it.
- Over-running the voice. The sessions are vocally heavy; rest the voice at the scheduled breaks (15-minute mid-evening, plus a 5-minute second break in the back half) and don't push through fatigue. Empower anyone — SM or cast — to call a two-minute "hold" as well.
- Mistaking the director's or script's permission for consent, or treating the company's own de-role/time-out practices as optional niceties. Consent lives with the actor receiving the action and is revocable at any moment, including in performance (protocol signature, lines 207/231); the absolute veto sits with the Step-Daughter and the Mother (line 122). The time-out word and check-out are practices the company writes for itself and agrees before they are needed.
- Mis-counting the charged material. There is no fixed "three charged events." Track the protocol's actual contact inventory (lines 132–148) — and remember the back room is reported, never staged, while the gunshot and drowning are object-handling, not intimacy work. The under-counted beat to watch is the "Cry out, mother!" contact (line 144), the most demanding actor-contact moment after the shop scene; name it explicitly in the Act Two session.

Where this comes from — further reading

- **Six Characters in Search of an Author — director's edition ([six_characters_village_players.html](#))** — Luigi Pirandello, adapted and directed by Kiarash Jamshidi (Storer translation, reworked). *The production's own master document. Source for every bespoke decision quoted in this plan: the Portraits gallery (the four-stage Father arc; the Mother as silent centre with her three silences, four fragile lines and the veil; the Step-Daughter as moral centre; the Son's refusal; the Manager who 'plays a director first', line 1601, and his Boy-chair pivot; Madame Pace as the conjured seventh Character / her own performer, line 1665; Player 3's pronoun left to the director, line 1647); the part-narrative playing-notes (lines 1891, 1990, 2332/2334, 3566, 3607); the Light & Sound score; the two stage objects; the three stripped settings. Its table-work schedule (lines 1782–1803) is SEVEN Thursdays, 18 June–30 July 2026; this plan deliberately COMPRESSES that into the five July Thursdays and says so — it does not claim a 'five-Thursday schedule' of the edition.*
- **Intimacy and Consent Protocol ([scripts/build_intimacy_protocol.py](#))** — Kiarash Jamshidi / Village Players. *The signed standalone contract. Source for 'Bounded bodies, unbounded moral force' (line 201); 'the intensity is in the report, not the display' (line 125); the back room never staged, carried by the Step-Daughter's account (line 114); the absolute veto for the Step-Daughter and Mother (line 122); the gunshot/drowning handled 'as object, not as person' (line 122); the full contact inventory (lines 132–148: 'My passion, sir!' hand-on-shoulder; the veil-lift with the Mother controlling speed, line 134; Madame Pace's hand under the chin; the shop-scene six-inch limit and screen disappearance; the 'Cry out mother' beat, the most demanding after the shop scene, line 144; the Mother separating them; the Father/Son grip, line 148); revocability including in performance (signature, lines 207/231). The protocol contains NO time-out word, check-in, de-role or intake channel — those are the production's own practices, not protocol clauses.*
- **The Director's Craft: A Handbook for the Theatre** — Katie Mitchell (Routledge, 2009). *The director-led world-building spine: facts and questions, back-history, the world of the play / big ideas, immediate circumstances (the 24 hours before), neutrally-named events, and intentions ('pictures of the future that drive present action'). Used to build the shared objective world before interpretation.*
- **Stanislavski's system (units & objectives, super-objective, through-line, active analysis)** — Konstantin Stanislavski; transmitted via Maria Knebel (Active Analysis, ed. Vasiliev) and Jane Baldwin's 'The Knebel

technique'. Source for units/objectives, super-objective and through-line, and the caution that grounds this plan's tightness: late in his career Stanislavski came to distrust long seated analysis for opening a gap between mental and physical work — 'the best analysis of a play is to take action in the given circumstances.' The substance is well-sourced; the specific 'twenty years' duration is a popularisation and is not asserted here. Hence we get up in August.

- **Actioning; Actions: The Actors' Thesaurus** — Max Stafford-Clark and Bill Gaskill (Joint Stock / later Out of Joint); Marina Caldarone & Maggie Lloyd-Williams (Nick Hern Books). *The line-level engine: assign one transitive, playable, present-tense verb per thought, fitting 'I ____ you', introduced only after events/intentions are agreed. The technique emerged from the Joint Stock workshop process co-led by Stafford-Clark and Gaskill in the late 1970s, so the cast holds it as a company rehearsal-room method, not one director's invention. Gives every line a recoverable, repeatable choice — vital for a semi-amateur company over a run. The thesaurus is the verb reference for the table.*
- **Respect for Acting / A Challenge for the Actor (the questions / six steps)** — Uta Hagen. *The actor's private prep checklist (Hagen preferred the later six steps): Who am I? / circumstances (especially 'what just happened') / relationships / what do I want? / obstacle / what do I do to get it? Dovetails with Mitchell's circumstances; used as homework so quiet roles prep as fully as leads.*
- **The Actor and the Target** — Declan Donnellan (Nick Hern Books, 2002/2005). *Keeps the work pointed outward: act toward a specific external target and what the character needs from it, rather than introspecting. 'You can never know what you are doing until you first know what you are doing it to.' Redirects any 'I feel...' note into action — keeps the Father from lecturing and protects against result-direction.*
- **Impro: Improvisation and the Theatre (status work)** — Keith Johnstone (1979). *The lens for the company/ensemble scenes in Act Two: status is played not possessed, the see-saw 'I go up and you go down', and play-the-status read-throughs (a point higher, then lower, then alternating). Makes the vain/working/curious Players-and-Manager dynamics legible and tunable, seated.*
- **L'Umorismo (On Humor)** — Luigi Pirandello (1908). *The source of the register this production turns on, and the distinction that makes it teachable: the merely comic is the avvertimento del contrario (the bare perception of the opposite — you laugh); umorismo proper is the sentimento del contrario (the reflective feeling that reverses the laugh into pain). The edition's 'earn the laugh, then let it curdle' IS the move from avvertimento to sentimento — named so the cast knows which half a flat beat is missing.*
- **Intimacy frameworks: IDC Five Pillars; Ita O'Brien's Intimacy On Set Guidelines; trauma-informed practice and aesthetic distance** — Intimacy Directors and Coordinators; Ita O'Brien; SAMHSA-derived principles via Nicolle Nattrass; 'aesthetic distance' / trauma-informed actor-training scholarship. *Governs the safety work and is the source of the production's OWN co-written practices (NOT the signed protocol): Context/Consent/Communication/Choreography/Closure; the time-out mechanism; consent lives with the receiving actor and is revocable; choreography is binding not improvised; private intake and check-in/de-role; depicting-not-reliving (aesthetic distance) so performers are not scarred by mining personal trauma. These are adopted into the Room & Safety Agreement in Session 1; the signed protocol is the separate contract cited for its own lines only.*
- **Practical guides to running the read-through and the table-work period** — Theatrefolk ('Having an Effective Table Read'); The Scene; Much Ado About Drama; Erin Joy Swank (breaks); Equity break standards. *Source for the room logistics: read for discovery not correction, don't direct from page one, read first/talk second, group work by relationship so no one sits idle, the prompt book in pencil with a key, a real break inside every 80 minutes (here honoured with a 15-minute mid-evening break PLUS a scheduled 5-minute second break in the charged back half), empowering the room to call breaks, and progressive off-book toward the floor.*

This plan is a researched scaffold, not a script for the evenings. Sessions may run longer or shorter inside the 18:00–21:00 window depending on the room; the architecture is what matters — each Thursday lays one course of the wall the August staging block will build on.